

Umwero Alphabet: The Flesh and Spirit of a new Writing System

I. Introduction

The Umwero alphabet is an African alphabet that is able to write all Ntu-related languages, but it is specifically for Kinyarwanda.

“Everything needs a spirit to begin, and flesh to be revealed.” ~ Kwizera Mugisha.

All languages are spirits. As people, we are spirits, and spirit is invisible, but through flesh it becomes visible. This is how a person can be seen, and every person has his or her flesh. Kwizera Mugisha, after reading Genesis 11:1–9 and Daniel 5:25, understood that every language must have its own script as a flesh to reveal its spirit. (In Rwandan traditions and beliefs, spirituality is the base. Let us now dive deep and learn about Umwero and how its characters are a real representation of Rwanda and the Kinyarwanda language.)

After discovering that Kinyarwanda writing has been changing repeatedly since 1911, I examined the history of those reforms. Over time, several scholars and officials introduced modifications:

- **1911** – Priest **Hurl E.** made the first recorded changes.
- **1921–1931** – Further adjustments were introduced by **Priest Schumacher P.**
- **1939** – Another reform came under **Bishop Classe L.**
- **1946** – **Priest Nkongoli L.** proposed additional changes.
- **1974** – A new reform was introduced by **Minister Bagaragaza Thaddée.**
- **1985** – **Minister Nsekaliye Aloys** introduced another change.
- **2012** – The **Inteko of Culture** made further modifications.
- **2024** – Another revision was made by **Inteko of Culture.**

All the above reasons made me create a stable writing system for Kinyarwanda that will remain consistent and preserve culture in language protection, and during those periods of changes many words and other cultural things were lost accordingly.

II. Description of the Umwero in General

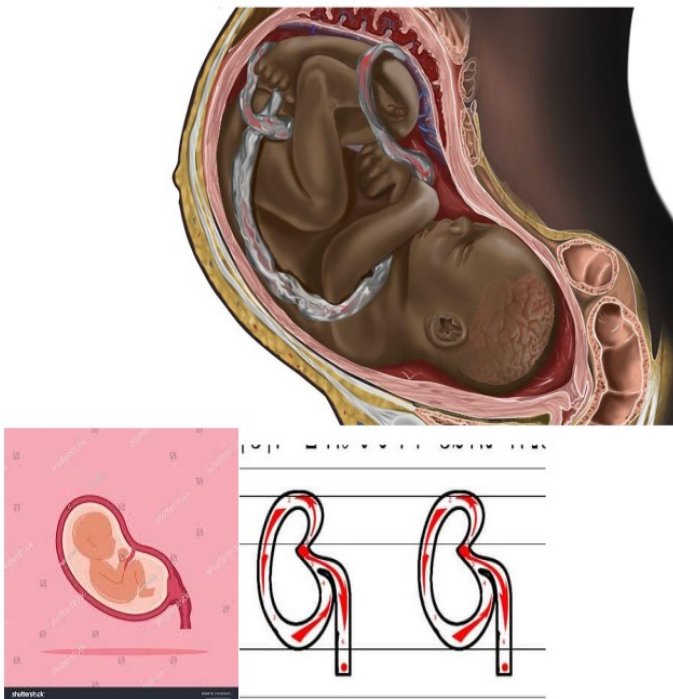
There is a saying in Kinyarwanda: “Izina ni ryo muntu,” meaning that a man’s name reveals who he is. Therefore, it is important to understand the meaning of Umwero. It does not only mean something as simple as a harvest. No, and when it is a harvest it is not in crops but in identity.

The name itself contains three pillars of Rwandan culture, which are **Imana, Inka, and Ingoma** (God, Cow, and Throne/Drums). When we take the name “Umwero” <U-mu-er/-o>, this ‘mu’ turns

II.1 Characters and Culture

II.1.1 Letter M and D

One for **DATA/DAWE/Daye** meaning father, the other for **Mama/Mawe/Maye**, so these two letters represent gender, where letter **M** reflects a womb (female), and letter **D** looks upward like a male symbol.

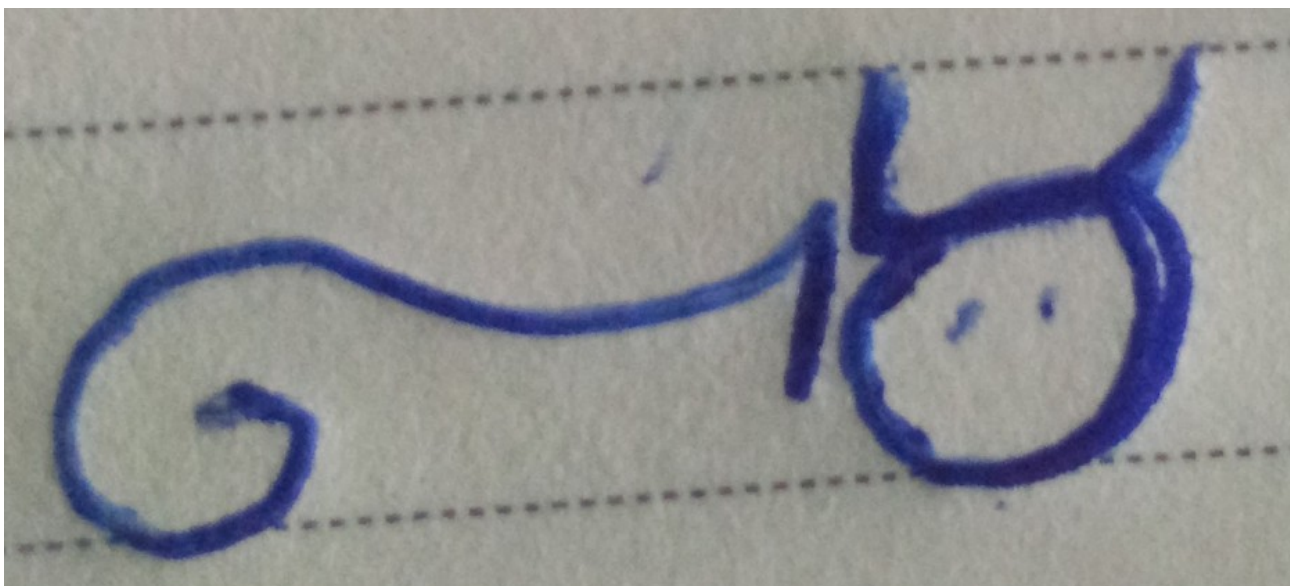
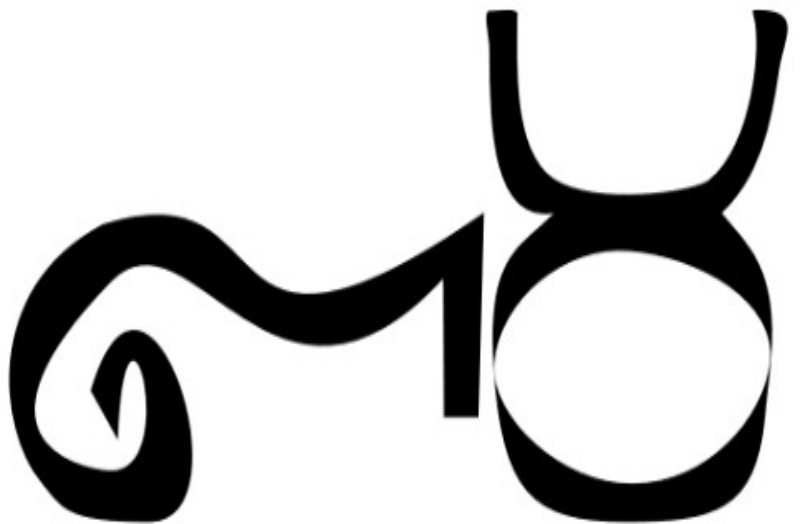


II.1.2 Letter A and B

For letters **B** and **A**, we see the best Rwandan respected treasure, which is a cow in the type of **Inyambo**.

Inyambo does not **moo** but **baas**, which we call *kwabira*. So **Inyambo irabira**. Then the Umwero letter **B** is the back part of a cow, while letter **A** is the head and horns.

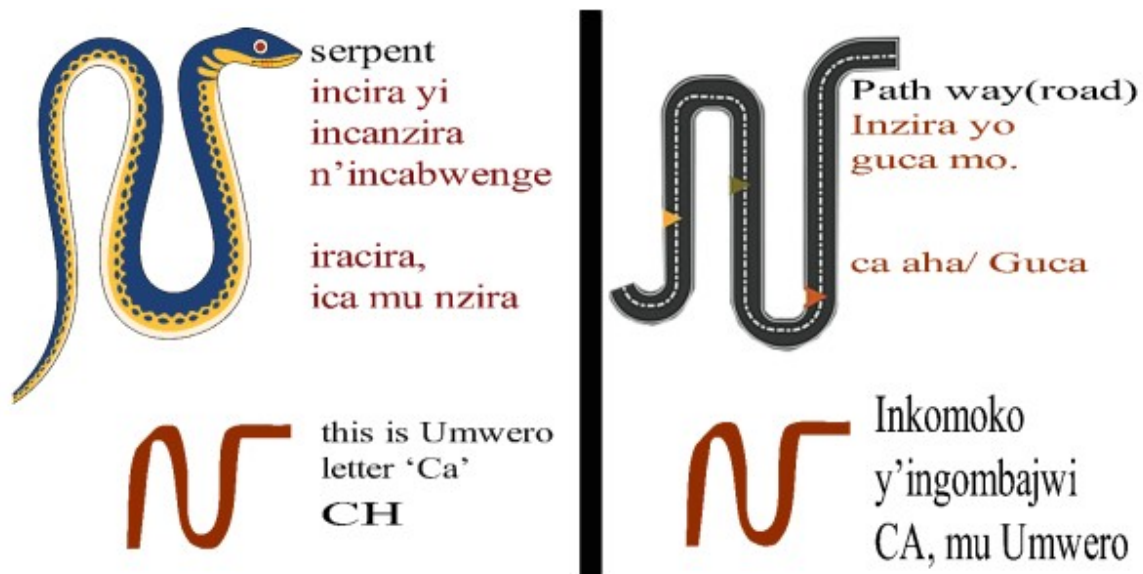
In short, letter **B** stands for **-abira** from *kwabira*.



II.1.3 Letter CH

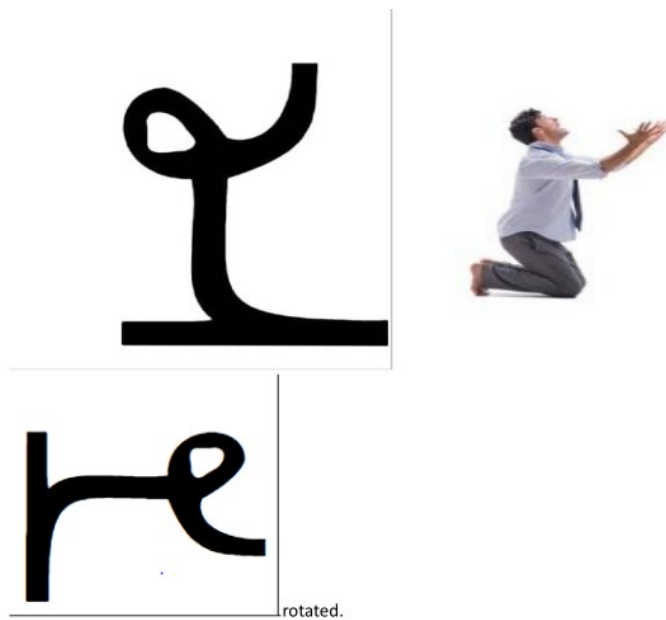
As in many cultures, a serpent is a symbol of wisdom. In Umwero a serpent is the letter **CH** for two reasons:

“Guca”: there is *guca* for passing in a way and *guca* for getting wisdom which we call “**guca akenge.**” Again, when you see a serpent standing, it shows a picture of a way too.



II.1.4 Letter R

Umwero letter **R** is for God, as God's names include **Ra, Rurema, Rugira**; many of God's names start with **Ra**. In the design I made a symbol that is like a pictograph of a person on their knees praying, then I rotated it to be seen well within the measurement of characters.



II.1.5 Hundreds Place Values

In Umwero numerals there is no such thing as zero, but all numbers are possible from **1 to decillions**, and amazingly the **four basic arithmetic operations** are possible because I organized the system to respect place values while calculating.

The way for this is called **growth of power**, which is *gukura kw'imbaraga*. The beginning of all glyphs in Umwero is a **circle**, which reflects **Life/God**, because a circle has no starting nor ending point, so it is both the start and the end, and that is God.



Figure 2: 43



Figure 1: tens

When it comes to numbers, this circle stands for **tens**. For example, when **3** is inside it means **thirty**. For **hundreds**, the power grows to be a **crown (Igisingo or Ikamba)**, the king's crown.

From our ancient philosophy it says **“Akami ka muntu ni umutima we,”** meaning you are the king of yourself. I respected that idea, and because our founding father is called **Gihanga**

Ngomijana, meaning *Gihanga of one hundred thrones*, I chose to make a crown stand for two different things:

- I. To represent a **proper noun** and revive the above proverb
- II. In numerals, to stand for **hundreds**, as our King Gihanga is of one hundred thrones, which protects his legacy.



Figure 4: hundreds and proper noun



Figure 3: 700

“here I need a help from typographers because all font I have the proper noun ain’t respected like that except when I use a pen”

II.1.5 Umwero Last Character

We have been discussing the first Umwero glyph/character, which represents **life**, and Rwandan ancestors believe that life is black and white: night and day, life and death.

As the first shape represents life, the last shape represents **death**, and that shape stands for the sound or consonant “**PF.**” Death in Kinyarwanda is **Urupfu.**

It is a circle, but a line passes through it to show the **destruction of life.**

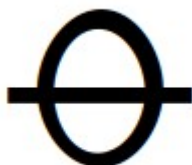


Figure 5: PF/-gupfa

III. Who Uses Umwero, Teaching, and Digitization

The Umwero alphabet is currently used by small groups of people. From **2022**, I started experimental teaching by introducing Umwero to my **two little brothers and their friend**, until they became **five children**. My brothers also shared the knowledge with a few of their friends at school, though I will not count them.



In **2023**, through my posts on **Facebook and Twitter**, someone called **Mucyo**, a Rwandan living in another country, learned Umwero by himself using my tweets and connected with me by sending Umwero texts written with both **pen and a keyboard**. The keyboard was very helpful to him, as he said. This experience showed me that **anyone can learn Umwero anywhere on their own**.

In **2024**, I was appointed as **secretary of a small church**, and I introduced Umwero to the church children, teaching them as well. I remember there were about **12 children**. Later that year, I had an opportunity to present Umwero on **television**, which brought the script to the attention of a wider audience. I then created **YouTube video tutorials**, allowing people from different areas, even in the **diaspora**, to learn Umwero. Some learners reached out to me for guidance and corrections, while others continued learning independently.



As most studies are online and I do not yet have a personal database, I am not sure how many students there are, but I can say with confidence that **the community is growing day by day**. From what I have observed, Umwero is especially loved by people who value **culture and Kinyarwanda**, as well as by those who want **privacy in writing**. While some learn it with less noble motivations, I continue teaching because **I know the direction I am guiding them toward**.

I teach **both in person and online**, but I prefer online teaching because it can reach learners everywhere. After discovering that people can learn independently, I decided to build **Uruziga**, a dedicated learning platform for Umwero.

Since I am busy with my studies, physical classes are currently difficult, except occasionally. The **Uruziga platform** will help track **how many students are learning, their progress, and their performance**. I am now preparing to build a **dataset**, which will later allow me to create an **OCR system** for Umwero. The final step in the digitization process will be submitting a **Unicode proposal**, ensuring that Umwero can be used widely on digital devices.